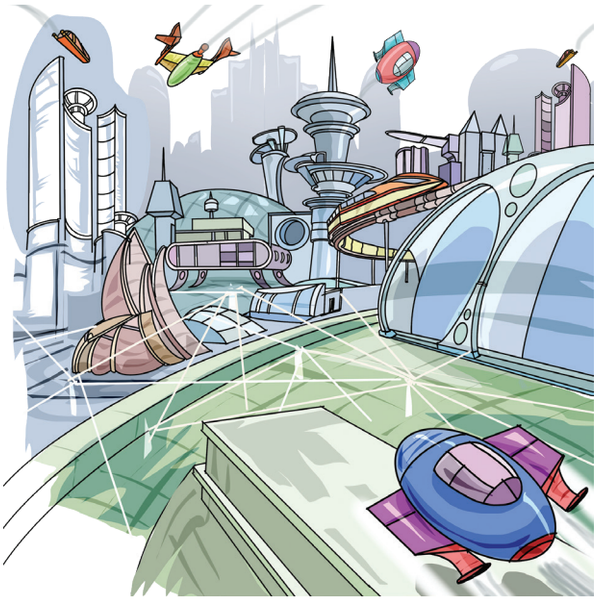
When he had finished his lunch, he went across to the window, where his aero-car was waiting.

'Where are we going, Sir?' asked the aero-coachman. 'Let's see. I've got time…' Francis Bennett replied. 'Take me to my accumulator works at Niagara.'

The aero-car shot across space at a speed of about four hundred miles an hour. Below him were spread out the towns with their moving pavements which carry the wayfarers along the streets, and the countryside, covered, as though by an immense spider's web, by the network of electric wires.



Within half an hour, Francis Bennett had reached his works at Niagara, where, after using the force of the cataracts to produce energy, he sold or hired it out to the consumers. Then he returned, by way of Philadelphia, Boston and New York, to Centropolis, where his aero-car put him down about five o'clock.

The waiting-room of the Earth Herald was crowded. A careful lookout was being kept for Francis Bennett to return for the daily audience he gave to his petitioners. Among their different proposals he had to make a choice, reject the bad ones, look into the doubtful ones, and welcome the good ones.

He soon got rid of those who had only useless or impracticable schemes. A few of the others received a better welcome, and foremost among them was a young man whose broad brow indicated a high degree of intelligence.

'Sir', he began, 'though the number of elements used to be estimated at seventy-five, it has now been reduced to three, as no doubt you are aware?'

'Perfectly,' Francis Bennett replied.

'Well, Sir, I'm on the point of reducing the three to one. If I don't run out of money I'll have succeeded in three weeks.'

'And then?'

'Then, Sir, I shall really have discovered the absolute'.

'And the results of that discovery?'

'It will be to make the creation of all forms of matter easy – stone, wood, metal, fibrin ….'

'Are you saying you're going to be able to construct a human being?'

'Complete… The only thing missing will be the soul!'

Francis Bennett assigned the young fellow to the scientific editorial department of his journal.

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